8-WEEK PLAN

# The Conjugate Method

*8 weeks, 6 days.*

**Days** 6 a week **Session** 60–75 min **Equipment** Full commercial gym
**Version** 2026-10-13

# What this is

Muscle grows from two different signals. The first is heavy tension: a set under a load that only allows a handful of reps, taken to the point where the next rep will not move. The second is metabolic stress: the pump, a muscle kept full of blood under short rest until it burns. Most programs make you choose one. This plan runs both in the same session, on the same muscle. One anchor set to real failure, a few bridge sets at two reps in reserve, then a seven-set finisher with the clock running. The anchor set comes from the heavy-duty tradition and the seven-set finisher from the pump tradition of pro bodybuilding. Running both in one session, with a bridge between them, is the part that's mine. The split is push, pull, legs, twice through, six days. Each day one priority muscle gets the full treatment and everything else gets quality work or a short top-up. The eight weeks are two four-week blocks: three weeks climbing a rep ladder at one load, one lighter week, then the same again heavier. Week 8 ends with a re-test against week 1, so you leave with a number, not a feeling.

**Who it's for**

- Advanced lifters, two or more years of consistent training.
- Six days a week available, 60 to 75 minutes a session.
- A full commercial gym.
- Sleep, food and stress already in order. This plan spends recovery, it does not create it.

**Who it's not for**

- Anyone under a year of training. Run Upper / Lower or Push / Pull / Legs first.
- Anyone who cannot train six days. The volume does not compress into four.
- Anyone in a hard cut. Failure work on a large deficit is how you get hurt and lose muscle at the same time.

Equipment: a full commercial gym. Barbells, heavy dumbbells, adjustable benches, a cable station with a rope and single handles, a hack squat or leg press, leg extension, seated leg curl, chest-supported row, pulldown, reverse pec deck and a hip thrust setup.

# Before you start

Five rules.

1. The plan is decided before the week starts. You do not pick exercises in the gym. You open the table and do what it says.
2. Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins. Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Use the seven-day average.
3. A missed day is data, not failure. It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet.
4. Log every session. The plan works off the record. Load, reps, and how many reps you had left, every set.
5. Progress is checked against the record, not how you feel. A session that felt bad and beat last week's numbers was a good session.

## Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights anywhere in this document. Week 1, session 1 of each day is a load-finding session. The rule for each set type:

- Quality set: a load you can lift for the bottom of the written rep range with two reps left. That is your start.
- Anchor set: the quality-set load plus 5 to 10 percent, so the bottom of the range is the last clean rep. If you get 6 or more in week 1 before failing, go up next session.
- Bridge sets: about 15 percent lighter than the anchor load on the same movement. On a different movement, the bottom of the range with two left.
- Finisher: a load you can do for 12 clean reps on set 1 with two left. It will feel light. By set 5 it will not.
- Top-ups: the bottom of the range with two left. Light and strict.

Write every starting load down in session 1. Weeks 2 and 3 are built on those numbers.

## The warm-up

Five to ten minutes, the same every session.

1. Three to five minutes on a bike or rower at a pace you can talk through.
2. Ten arm circles each way, ten leg swings each side, ten squats, ten band pull-aparts.
3. For the first movement of each muscle group: one or two ramp sets of 6 to 8 reps, light then moderate. Not counted, not in the tables.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

# The eight weeks

| WEEK | WHAT CHANGES | LOAD RULE | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Load-finding week. Bottom of every rep ladder. | Find and log every starting load. | Anchor sets to failure from day 1. Log the rest-pause reps. |
| 2 | One more rep per set. | Same load as week 1. | 6 becomes 7. 4 becomes 5. |
| 3 | One more rep per set. | Same load. Top of the ladder. | Note every set that hit the top. |
| 4 | Deload. | Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load. | Three to four in reserve. No anchor sets, no finishers. |
| 5 | New block. Bottom of the ladder. | Up 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones, wherever week 3 hit the top. | Otherwise same load, ladder again. |
| 6 | One more rep per set. | Same load as week 5. | |
| 7 | One more rep per set. | Same load. Top of the ladder. | The heaviest week of the plan. |
| 8 | Deload and re-test. | Deload rules, plus the re-test below. | The number you walk away with. |

## The ladder

Weeks 1 to 3 are one block. The load does not change. The reps do. Every set is written as a ladder: 6→7→8 means six reps in week 1, seven in week 2, eight in week 3, at the same weight. Anchor sets run 4→5→6 the same way, each week to failure plus rest-pause. The finisher runs its own ladder at one load across all seven sets.

Week 4 is the deload. Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, three to four reps in reserve on every set. The anchor sets come out. The finisher comes out and is replaced by two easy sets of the same movement. Top-ups stay, lighter. The abs circuit runs two rounds. The deload is not a week off. It is the week the growth from weeks 1 to 3 gets built.

Week 5 starts the second block. Every movement that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve goes up: 5 to 10 lb on presses, rows, squats and deadlifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on curls, raises, extensions and flyes, back to the bottom of the ladder. Any movement that did not reach the top keeps its load and runs the ladder again. Weeks 6 and 7 add a rep each.

Week 8 is the second deload, with one addition. In the last session of each day type, the quality set of every anchor movement is done at week 1's load for week 1's reps. You will not fail it. The point is to count what is left. In week 1 that load had one or two reps in reserve. In week 8 it should have three, four or more. Log the difference for each movement. No anchor sets to failure in week 8 and no finishers.

## Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload the same week, then you resume the block where you left it.

- Performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row.
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy.
- A week of bad sleep.

## Load-drop rules

If one muscle is going backwards while the rest of the body is fine, you do not need a full deload. Cut that muscle's sets by 30 to 40 percent for one week, top-up sets first. The anchor set and the finisher on its priority day are the last things to touch. If two muscles are dropping at once, that is recovery, not programming. Deload.

# The sessions

Exercise names carry the set type, so a muscle's work reads top to bottom: quality set, anchor set, bridge sets, finisher. Tempo is four digits: seconds down, pause at the bottom, seconds up, pause at the top. 3-0-1-0 is three seconds down, no pause, one second up, no pause. On the anchor set the last reps slow down on their own. That is fine. Rest is written per row and it is timed, not felt.

**The quality set.** One working set at one or two reps in reserve, at the heaviest load you can control for the reps written. It counts.

**The anchor set.** One set to real failure, then rest-pause. Real failure means the next rep would not move with good form, not the point where it gets uncomfortable. Rack the weight. Count fifteen to twenty seconds. Unrack and get two or three more reps. Rack it. That is the set. One per muscle per session, never two. Three minutes rest after it.

**The bridge sets.** Back-off work at two reps in reserve, strict. About 15 percent lighter than the anchor load on the same movement. The bridge adds mechanical work without spending the recovery the anchor set already spent. Never to failure. Two minutes rest on compounds, 90 seconds on isolations.

**The finisher.** Seven sets of one movement at one load, 30 to 45 seconds rest between sets, timed. Sets one to six stop at one or two reps in reserve. Set seven goes past failure with partial reps or one drop in load. The rest is short enough that the muscle never empties. It stays full of blood the whole time, and that swelling is the second growth signal. Only the priority muscle gets one.

**The top-up sets.** Two sets at two reps in reserve for a muscle that is not the day's priority. Sixty seconds rest. Never to failure. They are the first thing cut when time or recovery is short.

**The clock.** Sessions fit 60 to 75 minutes with the rests timed. If you hit 75 minutes, drop the top-up sets first, then cut the abs circuit to two rounds. The priority muscle's anchor set, bridge sets and finisher are never cut for time.

## Day 1: Push A

Focus: chest and shoulders, both with the full treatment. Biceps top-up.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Incline dumbbell press, quality set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Two ramp sets first, not counted. |
| Incline dumbbell press, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | To failure, then rest-pause: rack 15 to 20 seconds, two or three more reps. |
| Incline dumbbell press, bridge set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | About 15 percent lighter than the anchor load. Two in reserve. |
| Flat dumbbell press, bridge | 2 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Two in reserve. |
| Low-to-high cable fly, finisher | 7 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Same load all seven sets. Sets 1 to 6 one or two in reserve. Set 7 past failure with partials. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seated dumbbell shoulder press, quality set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Ramp sets first. |
| Seated dumbbell shoulder press, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. |
| Cable lateral raise, bridge | 3 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Lead with the elbow. |
| Leaning cable lateral raise, finisher | 7 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Hold the frame and lean away from the stack. Set 7 past failure. |
| Hammer curl, top-up | 2 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-0 | 60 s | Strict. |
| Straight-bar cable curl, top-up | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-0 | 60 s | Strict. |

Substitutions: no heavy enough incline dumbbells, use an incline machine press. No low-to-high cable, use a pec deck with the handles set low or an incline dumbbell fly. No cable for laterals, use dumbbell lateral raises, seated for the bridge, standing for the finisher. No hammer dumbbells, use a rope hammer curl.

## Day 2: Pull A

Focus: back and biceps. Back gets two anchor sets, a pulldown for width and a row for thickness. Rear and side delts top-up.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Cable pullover, activation | 2 | 10→11→12 | 2-1-1-1 | 2:00 | Zero or one in reserve. Wakes the lats before the heavy work. Full stretch at the top. |
| Wide-grip pulldown, quality set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Width. |
| Wide-grip pulldown, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. |
| Underhand barbell row, quality set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Thickness. Torso slightly upright, pull to the hip. |
| Underhand barbell row, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. This builds the lower lat. |
| Underhand barbell row, bridge set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | About 15 percent lighter. Two in reserve. |
| Overhead cable pullover, finisher | 7 | 12→13→14 | 2-1-1-1 | 30–45 s | Big stretch at the top, full lat contraction at the bottom. Set 7 past failure. |
| EZ-bar curl, quality set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | One or two in reserve. |
| EZ-bar curl, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Incline dumbbell curl, bridge | 2 | 8→9→10 | 3-1-1-0 | 90 s | Arm hangs behind the body. Stretched position. |
| Behind-the-body cable curl, finisher | 7 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Face away from the stack, arm behind the body. Constant tension. Set 7 past failure. |
| Reverse pec deck, top-up | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Strict. |
| Prone incline rear delt raise, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Chest on the bench, palms down, arms straight. Torso locked so the traps stay out of it. |

Substitutions: no cable pullover, use a dumbbell pullover. No pulldown, use weighted pull-ups, same sets and reps. No barbell for the row, use an underhand chest-supported machine row or a single-arm dumbbell row. No EZ-bar, use a straight bar or dumbbells. No incline bench for curls, use a cable curl facing away from the stack. No reverse pec deck, use bent-over dumbbell rear delt raises.

## Day 3: Legs A

Focus: quads. Hamstrings and glutes bridge work, abs circuit, shoulders and biceps top-up.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Hack squat, quality set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Ramp sets first. Feet mid-platform. |
| Hack squat, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. Set the safety stops before the set. |
| Leg press, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Zero to two in reserve. |
| Leg extension, finisher | 7 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Seat reclined if the machine allows. Set 7 past failure with partials. |
| Bulgarian split squat, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 each side | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Front foot forward, knee tracks over the toe. |
| Romanian deadlift, bridge | 2 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Hinge, soft knees, bar on the thighs. |
| Seated leg curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Zero or one in reserve. Optional drop on the last set. |
| Cable crunch, abs circuit | 4 | 20 | 2-0-1-1 | none | Pull with the abs, not the arms. Control the return. |
| Hanging leg raise, abs circuit | 4 | 15 | 2-0-1-0 | none | No swing. Control the descent every rep. |
| Dead bug, abs circuit | 3 | 8 each side | 2-0-2-0 | none | Back flat on the floor the whole time. Skill work, not conditioning. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Anti-rotation cable press, abs circuit | 3 | 12 each side | 1-2-1-0 | 60 s after the round | Ribs down. Resist the twist. |
| Lateral raise, top-up | 2 | 20→21→22 | 2-0-1-0 | 60 s | Light and strict. |
| Prone incline rear delt raise, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Palms down, arms straight. |
| Rope hammer curl, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-0 | 60 s | Strict. |

The abs circuit runs as a circuit: no rest between the four movements, 60 seconds after each round. Rounds 1 to 3 are all four movements. Round 4 is the cable crunch and the hanging leg raise only.

Substitutions: no hack squat, use a machine squat or a leg press with the feet low. No leg press, use a heavy goblet squat. No leg extension, use a sissy squat and accept a weaker finisher. No setup for the split squat, use walking lunges, 20 steps each leg. No cable crunch, use a weighted crunch holding a plate. No hanging bar, use lying leg raises. No cable for the anti-rotation press, use a band.

## Day 4: Push B

Focus: shoulders and triceps. Chest volume with one anchor set. Biceps volume.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Flat barbell or machine press, quality set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Ramp sets first. |
| Flat barbell or machine press, anchor set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. On a barbell, a spotter or safety pins. |
| Flat barbell or machine press, bridge set | 1 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | About 15 percent lighter. Two in reserve. |
| Incline machine press, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Two in reserve. |
| Cable fly, bridge | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-1-1-1 | 90 s | Deep stretch at the bottom. |
| Machine shoulder press or high-incline press, quality set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | One or two in reserve. |
| Machine shoulder press or high-incline press, anchor set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. |
| Machine shoulder press or high-incline press, bridge set | 1 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | About 15 percent lighter. Two in reserve. |
| Cable lateral raise, bridge | 3 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Two in reserve. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Dumbbell lateral raise, finisher | 7 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Same dumbbells all seven sets. Set 7 past failure with partials. |
| EZ-bar or cable curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 90 s | Two in reserve. |
| Incline dumbbell curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-1-1-0 | 90 s | Last set, one drop in load, then keep going to two in reserve. |
| Close-grip machine press, quality set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Elbows tucked at about 30 degrees. |
| Close-grip machine press, anchor set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | Failure plus rest-pause. Heavy and controlled. |
| Overhead cable extension, bridge | 3 | 10→11→12 | 3-1-1-0 | 90 s | Full stretch behind the head, elbows in. The long head grows here. Never skip it. |
| Rope pushdown, finisher | 7 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Split the rope at the bottom and turn the hands out. Set 7 past failure. |

Substitutions: no machine press, use a dumbbell bench press. No incline machine, use an incline dumbbell press. No cable fly, use a pec deck or dumbbell fly. No machine shoulder press, use a seated dumbbell press. No close-grip machine, use a close-grip barbell bench or a dip machine. No overhead cable, use a two-hand dumbbell overhead extension. No rope, use a straight-bar pushdown.

## Day 5: Pull B

Focus: back, on a volume day. One anchor set, no finisher. Biceps volume, shoulders top-up. The short day of the week.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Wide-grip pulldown, bridge | 2 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Ramp sets first. |
| Chest-supported row, anchor set | 1 | 6→7→8 | 2-0-1-0 | 3:00 | The one anchor set of the day. Failure plus rest-pause. |
| Single-arm cable row, bridge | 2 | 12→13→14 each side | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Full stretch forward, elbow to the hip. |
| Straight-arm pulldown, bridge | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Arms nearly straight. Lats only. |
| Preacher curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 90 s | Two in reserve. |
| Behind-the-body cable curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Face away from the stack. |
| Chest-supported rear delt row, top-up | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Elbows wide and high. |
| Reverse pec deck, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Strict. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Lateral raise, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-0 | 60 s | Strict. |

Substitutions: no chest-supported row machine, use a dumbbell row with the chest on an incline bench. No pulldown, use pull-ups. No single-arm cable, use a single-arm dumbbell row. No straight-arm pulldown, use a dumbbell pullover. No preacher bench, use a spider curl over the high side of an incline bench. No rear delt row, use bent-over dumbbell rear delt raises.

## Day 6: Legs B

Focus: hamstrings and glutes. Quads volume, abs circuit, shoulders and biceps pump to close the week.

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Romanian deadlift, quality set | 1 | 8→9→10 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:30 | Ramp sets first. |
| Romanian deadlift, anchor set | 1 | 4→5→6 | 3-0-1-0 | 3:00 | To failure with good form, no rest-pause on this one. A hinge gets no second attempt when the back is tired. |
| Seated leg curl, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Zero or one in reserve. Drop on the last set. |
| Hip thrust, bridge | 2 | 8→9→10 | 2-0-1-1 | 2:00 | Chin down, ribs down, full lockout. |
| Seated leg curl or hip thrust machine, finisher | 7 | 10→11→12 | 2-0-1-1 | 30–45 s | Same load all seven. Set 7 past failure with partials. |
| Bulgarian split squat, glute focus, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 each side | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Lean the torso slightly forward to load the glute. |
| Leg press or hack squat, bridge | 2 | 10→11→12 | 3-0-1-0 | 2:00 | Two in reserve. |
| Leg extension, bridge | 2 | 12→13→14 | 2-0-1-1 | 90 s | Two in reserve. |
| Cable crunch, abs circuit | 4 | 20 | 2-0-1-1 | none | Pull with the abs. Full range. Control the return. |
| Hanging leg raise, abs circuit | 4 | 15 | 2-0-1-0 | none | No swing. Control the descent. |

| EXERCISE | SETS | REPS | TEMPO | REST | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Dead bug, abs circuit | 3 | 8 each side | 2-0-2-0 | none | Back flat to the floor throughout. |
| Anti-rotation cable press, abs circuit | 3 | 12 each side | 1-2-1-0 | 60 s after the round | Ribs down. Closes every leg session. |
| Lateral raise, pump series, top-up | 2 | 25→26→27 | 1-0-1-0 | 60 s | Rest-pause style. Break each set into short bursts, two in reserve on every burst. |
| Prone incline rear delt raise, top-up | 2 | 15→16→17 | 2-0-1-1 | 60 s | Palms down, arms straight. |
| Band or cable curl, pump, top-up | 2 | 20→21→22 | 1-0-1-0 | 60 s | Strict. |

The abs circuit runs exactly as on Day 3.

Substitutions: no seated leg curl, use a lying leg curl for the bridge and the finisher. No hip thrust setup, use a barbell glute bridge on the floor or a glute machine. No setup for the split squat, use walking lunges, 20 steps each leg, torso forward. No leg press and no hack squat, use a heavy goblet squat.

### The week

| DAY | SESSION | PRIORITY MUSCLE | EVERYTHING ELSE |
|---|---|---|---|
| Monday | Push A | Chest and shoulders | Biceps top-up |
| Tuesday | Pull A | Back and biceps | Rear and side delts top-up |
| Wednesday | Legs A | Quads | Hamstrings and glutes bridge, abs circuit, shoulders and biceps top-up |
| Thursday | Push B | Shoulders and triceps | Chest volume with one anchor set, biceps volume |
| Friday | Pull B | Back | Biceps volume, shoulders top-up |
| Saturday | Legs B | Hamstrings and glutes | Quads volume, abs circuit, shoulders and biceps pump |
| Sunday | Off | None | Walk, stretch, mobility. No lifting. |

There is no rolling alternative. The six sessions sit on fixed days so each muscle's feature day lands 72 hours after its last heavy work. A missed day is slotted in on the next free day, never doubled.

## Progression and troubleshooting

**Adding load.** Load changes once per block, at the start of week 5, and only on movements that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve. 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones. Mid-block the load holds and the reps climb. If an anchor set gets to 6 or more in week 1 before failing, the load was wrong, not the plan. Go up next session and restart that movement's ladder.

**A stalled lift.** A lift stalls when the reps do not climb at the same load two weeks running. Hold the load. Add reps where you can, even one on one set. If it is still stalled after two weeks, drop the load 10 percent, run the ladder from the bottom, and climb back. You will pass the old number on the way up. Grinding at the old load is how a stall becomes a month.

**A missed session.** Slot it in on the next free day and push the rest of the week along by one. Never double up. Two missed sessions in the same week means the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B from the compliance page for the rest of the week and start the next week on schedule. The log tells you where you were.

**Poor sleep.** A night under six hours caps that day. Quality set and bridge sets only, no anchor set to failure, no set 7 past failure. The finisher runs as seven sets at two in reserve. A week of it is a deload trigger.

**Failing safely.** An anchor set to failure is safe when the setup is right. Safety stops set before the set. A spotter on a barbell press. Dumbbells you can drop. Failure on the Romanian deadlift is form failure, the rep where the back wants to round. If you cannot set a movement up safely, take the machine version from the substitutions to failure instead.

**When to stop.** Muscle fatigue is dull, spread out, and goes away with rest. Pain that is sharp, in a joint, on one side, or that changes how you move is not fatigue. Stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

# Cardio and walking

Walk most days, 20 to 40 minutes, at a pace you could hold a conversation at. On this plan that is the cardio. Six lifting days with anchor sets and finishers already spend the recovery budget. Hard conditioning on top comes out of muscle, not fat.

Sunday is walking, stretching and mobility only. Nothing that leaves you sore for Monday.

Hard cardio is optional and this plan does not ask for it. If you want it, one short session on Sunday, easy enough that Monday is unaffected. Never before lifting.

# The compliance page

## Plan A, the full week

- All six sessions done, on their days.
- All six sessions logged, rest-pause reps included.
- Protein target hit every day, 1 g per lb of bodyweight as the default line.
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded.
- Walks done.

## Plan B, the bare minimum

When the week blows up, Plan B is a full week. Three sessions: one push, one pull, one legs. Run Push A, Pull A and Legs A, and in each one do only the quality set and the anchor set for every anchor movement. No bridge sets, no finishers, no top-ups, no abs circuit. One hard set per muscle keeps the stimulus alive and the session takes 25 to 35 minutes. Protein still hit. Sessions still logged. A Plan B week counts as a week done.

## Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

## The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

## Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom. Log it.
- Photos front, side, back, same light, same place.
- Read the whole of week 1 before day 1. Every table, every note.
- Put the six session days in a calendar now, with the time.
- Pick the Plan B days now, before you need them. One push, one pull, one legs.

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*Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.*

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Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.